JAMES MCKENZIE

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Location: Edinburgh, United Kingdom

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Staff Engineer with 14 years of experience building scalable backend systems and leading technical initiatives across fintech and SaaS companies. I've spent the last six years at director-level companies working on high-throughput distributed systems that process millions of transactions daily. I'm equally comfortable deep in infrastructure code as I am unblocking teams and setting technical direction. Based in Edinburgh and looking for opportunities where I can mentor while pushing technical boundaries.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Staff Engineer

Nexus Financial Technologies

nexus-fintech.io

London, United Kingdom

March 2020 - Present

Designed and implemented a microservices migration that reduced API response times by 65% and improved system reliability from 99.5% to 99.99% uptime for our payments platform serving 500+ enterprise clients.

Led a team of 8 engineers through a major refactoring of our core transaction processing engine, cutting production incidents by 72% and establishing new standards for code review and testing practices.

Architected a real-time analytics pipeline using Kafka and Apache Flink that processes 2 million events per second, enabling product teams to make data-driven decisions with sub-second latency.

Mentored 5 junior and mid-level engineers, two of whom were promoted to senior roles, while establishing an internal guild for distributed systems knowledge sharing.

Senior Software Engineer

DataStream Solutions Ltd

datastream.co.uk

Edinburgh, United Kingdom

September 2015 - February 2020

Built and maintained a cloud data warehouse supporting 50+ petabytes of customer data, implementing query optimization techniques that improved performance by 8x and reduced infrastructure costs by 40%.

Developed a comprehensive monitoring and alerting system using Prometheus and Grafana that reduced mean time to resolution for production issues from 45 minutes to 8 minutes.

Collaborated with the security team to implement end-to-end encryption for sensitive data at rest and in transit, ensuring compliance with GDPR and ISO 27001 standards.

Conducted regular technical interviews and assessments for hiring, helping build an engineering team that grew from 12 to 35 people while maintaining high quality standards.

Software Engineer

Catalyst Digital

catalyst-digital.net

Glasgow, United Kingdom

June 2009 - August 2015

Developed backend services using Java and Spring Framework for a digital advertising platform that reached 100 million impressions monthly, handling peak traffic of 50,000 requests per second.

Implemented automated deployment pipelines using Jenkins and Docker, reducing deployment time from 2 hours to 12 minutes and enabling the team to ship code 10 times more frequently.

Designed and built a distributed caching layer using Redis that improved application performance by 55% and reduced database load significantly during peak usage periods.

Worked across teams to establish coding standards and best practices, introducing pair programming sessions that reduced bug escape rates by 30% and improved knowledge sharing across the department.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science in Computer Science

University of Edinburgh

Edinburgh, United Kingdom

Graduated June 2009

GPA: 2:1

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: Java, Python, Go, SQL, JavaScript, Kotlin

Distributed Systems: Microservices architecture, eventual consistency, distributed transactions, load balancing, service discovery

Databases: PostgreSQL, MySQL, MongoDB, Redis, Apache Cassandra, Elasticsearch, data warehousing concepts

Cloud and DevOps: AWS (EC2, S3, Lambda, RDS, DynamoDB), Docker, Kubernetes, Terraform, CI/CD pipelines, Jenkins

Message Queues and Streaming: Apache Kafka, RabbitMQ, Apache Flink, event-driven architecture

Monitoring and Observability: Prometheus, Grafana, ELK Stack, distributed tracing, SLO and SLI definition

Core Competencies: System design, technical leadership, code review, mentoring, performance optimization, production incident response